

## Excerpts from *A Short History of the Sikhs* by Teja Singh & Ganda Singh

### PARTONE

### RELIGIOUS FOUNDATIONS

#### THE SIKH GURUS

'Sikh' (Sanskrit *shishya*) means a disciple; and his religion is best understood when it is regarded as a life, a discipline, and not as a system of philosophy. Sikh history reveals the gradual making and development of a nation in the hands of successive leaders, called *Gurus*. They had much in common with other contemporary reformers who were doing so much to purify religion and enrich vernacular literature; but these reformers appear to have been so impressed with the nothingness of this life that they deemed it unworthy of a thought to build up a new order of society. In the words of Joseph Cunningham, 'they aimed chiefly at emancipation from priest craft, or from the grossness of idolatry and polytheism...

They perfected forms of dissent rather than planted germs of nations, and their *sects* remain to this day as they left them. It was reserved for Nanak to perceive the true principles of reform, and to lay those foundations which enabled his successor Gobind to fire the minds with a new nationality, and to give practical effect to the doctrine that the lowest is equal with the highest, in race as in creed, in political rights as in religious hopes. It is the glory of Sikh history that the Gurus had in mind the duties of a nation as much as the duties of an individual.

If studied from this point of view all apparent contradictions of Sikh history would vanish. There would seem to be no break, no digression in the programme of Sikh Life. It was like an organism experiencing change even while it performed its work, developing new organs and functions, because it was daily challenged to exercise new energies. Its principle of life remained the same, though it underwent a constant transfiguration (not 'transformation', as some writers have put it), assuming a great variety of forms, caused solely by local and occasional circumstances.

#### 1 GURU NANAK (1469-1539)

The movement began with Guru Nanak, who was born on April 15, 1469 (Vaisakh sum 3, 1526 Bk.), in the Kshatrya clan at TaJvandi Rai Bhoey, now called Nankana Sahib, about 40 miles to the south-west of Lahore. His father, Mehta Kalu, was a Patvari or village accountant to the Bhatti landlord named Rai Bular. At the age of seven Nanak was put to the village school under a Brahmin teacher from whom he learnt arithmetic and book-keeping, besides reading and writing in Devnagri. He soon exhausted the stock of learning that the village teacher possessed, and went to a local Maulvi<sup>2</sup> for the study of Persian and Islamic literature. When he grew up, he supplemented his knowledge by associating with the saints and hermits found in the neighbouring forest. He was deeply interested in Indian lore in general and in the writings of the contemporary bhagats in particular, whose teachings he compared with his own and criticised in passing. His scholarly attainments were considerable as shown by his erudite compositions like the *Japji*, *Asa-di-Var*, *'Sidh GCKih*, and *Onkir*. During his long tours he visited different centres of Hindu and Muslim faiths, and acquainted himself with their systems. He often referred to ancient writers, made apt use of classical stories,<sup>2</sup> and had philosophical discussions with learned Yogis, Pandits, and Sufis, whom he was always able to convince by his deep learning and hard common-sense. The architectural

design of his compositions and his epigrammatic style, closely packed with reflective thought on great problems of life, bear ample Witness to his being a scholarly writer.<sup>3</sup> From the beginning he had a protestant and critical frame of mind. At the age of nine, when he was asked to go through the ceremony of *Yajnopavitam*, he refused to wear the sacred thread, saying that he would rather have a thread that would 'neither break, nor get soiled, nor be burnt or lost' (*V. AsS*; xv. I).

***He takes up his mission:*** Early one morning as usual he went to bathe at the neighbouring river of Baeen. The scene so struck his poetic mind that he went into a trance and communed with the Spirit pervading the whole universe. He felt that he stood before the throne of the Almighty, and received from Him the message of his mission. When he reappeared after three days, he was a changed man. He gave away all he had to the poor, and kept silent. Whenever he was urged to speak, he only said : 'There is no Hindu, no Mussalman.' It was a fit formula for the commencement of his mission, which was to reconcile the two warring communities of India into one brotherhood by showing them how they had fallen from their high ideals and had forgotten God their common Father.

This was a turning point in the life of Nanak. He left the service of Daulat Khan, and entered on his mission as a teacher of the world. This took place in 1496, when he was 27 years old. He took Bhai Mardana, his rebeck-player and devoted follower, with him. He was very fond of music, and most of his messages were sung to his audiences to the accompaniment of six-stringed rebeck, called *rabab*, which was his own invention.<sup>3</sup> First he spent some time in the Panjab, converting Hindus and Muslims to his views and establishing *Manjis* or missionary centres wherever he went. At Saidpur (now called Eminabad) he put up at the house of a carpenter, named *Lalo*. This strange combination of a so-called Khatri saint with a low-caste Mohammedan minstrel, living and dining with a Hindu Sudra, became the subject of common talk. Mere gossip turned into severe criticism when Guru Nanak refused to participate in the grand feast given by Malik Bhago, a Hindu official of the local Pathan Faujdar. The Guru was called by the Malik who remonstrated with him for preferring to dine with a low-caste carpenter and refusing to accept the invitation of a high-caste man like himself. The Guru called for a dish from the sumptuous feast of the Malik and also a piece of coarse bread from the house of his poor host. Holding the two in his hands he said that he saw wholesome milk issuing from the honestly-earned bread of Lalo and red blood of tortured humanity trickling from the rich dainties of Malik Bhago. 'I recognise no caste,' he said. 'There is only one brotherhood, that of humanity; and only one pollution, that of separateness.' Lalo was appointed to the first *Manji*, which was to spread Sikhism in the northern Punjab.

### **Pg 13 – 16:**

***Estimate of His Work:*** It is usual to say that Guru Nanak was a man of devotion and peace, and did not think of the worldly needs of his people. This is entirely a wrong notion. The Guru did think of the social and political disabilities of his people; otherwise he would not have said:

Sin is the king, Greed the minister, Falsehood the mint-master,  
And lust the deputy to take counsel with; they sit and confer together.  
The blind subjects, out of ignorance, pay homage like dead men.

(Asa di Var. xvi)

He rebuked 'the masters of the herd', the Lodhi Pathans, for not putting up a stiff fight for India, and allowing such a precious gem to be snatched away easily by the foreigner. To quote his own words:

If the dogs of Lodhis have thrown away the priceless inheritance;  
when they are dead, no one will remember them with regard.

(*Asa*)

He complained that the people were so cowed down in spirit that 'they mimicked the Mohammedan manners', 'ate meat prepared in the Mohammedan fashion', and 'wore blue dress in order to please the ruling class' (*Var Asa*). 'In every home people called themselves by foreign names. Even their language had changed.' (*Basant*)

Looking at the helplessness of his countrymen, he discovered that moral degradation was at the root of it all. When asked by his companion, Mardana, why such a suffering had come to the people during the foreign invasion, he replied: 'It is ordained by the Creator that before coming to a fall one is deprived of one's virtue' (*Asa*). He felt sure that, as long as men were steeped in ignorance and corruption, nothing could be done for them. He freed them from the bondage of so many gods and goddesses, and led them to accept one Supreme Being as the creator and sustainer of all no matter by what name they called Him. He could not be worshipped in the form of an image; the devotee was to practice His presence by dwelling on His Name. There were no incarnations. no special revelations. Mail \a~ the highest manifestation of God, who spoke more frequently through the heart of man than through scriptures. With the uplift of man, woman also received her due. She was declared not only not inferior to man but as having an equal responsibility for her actions before God (*Var Asa*. xix). To give a practical shape to the idea of equality, the Guru instituted the custom of interdining in a common mess attached to every place of worship. No devotion or programme of life was genuine which did not lead to the love of mankind, which in practice must mean social service. He laid down very simple rules of conduct, which did not forge any new shackles in place of the old ones, and left the people to work out their social conscience themselves:

Put away the custom that makes you forget the Loved One (*Wadhans*)

My friend, the enjoyment of that food is evil.

Which gives pain to the body and evil thoughts to the mind.

(*Sri /Rag*).

By adopting the vernacular of the country for religious purposes he, in a way, roused the national sentiment of the people. It was strengthened by the community of thought and ideal, daily realised in the congregational singing of the same religious hymns. It also improved the understanding of the people. The high truths conveyed to them in their own tongue made them conscious of new powers of thought in themselves. To this was added the illumination of intellect which comes with the sincerity and enthusiasm of a newly-found faith.

In order to work out his ideas in practice, Guru Nanak set a personal example of pure life lived in the midst of the world. In his youth he was a store-keeper under the government, a good householder and a loving brother. In old age, after several years spent in travelling and preaching, he settled down at Kartarpur as a farmer.

He had done all this, but much had still to be done before a people morally and physically degraded could lift up their heads and come into their own again. The religion he had founded was not to remain content with the salvation of a few individuals. It had far nobler potentialities in it. It was to organise itself as a world-force, and evolve a living and energetic society for the uplift of mankind. That the Guru was not a mere reformer but the founder of a new religion is clear from the fact that he travelled abroad to non-Hindu countries, established Sangats<sup>1</sup> or Sikh organizations in different centres under the charge of Manji-holders, and took special care to test and appoint a successor who should continue his work after him:

He tested his Sikhs and his sons, and his followers saw what they had done.  
It was when Lehna was tested and purified that Guru Nanak consecrated him.

He took him to his seat and calling him *Angad*, the flesh of his flesh and the bone of his bone, saluted him as his successor. He died soon after, on September 22, 1539.

Yet a little, ere it fled,  
Did he resign his high and holy soul  
To images of the majestic past,  
That paused within his passive being now.

As he lay on his death-bed at Kartarpur, the different scenes of Talvandi in the *Bar*, his homeland, came up before his mind's eye one after another, and reminded him of his early surroundings. 'Ah,' said he in the last piece ever written by him, 'now the *Van* tree must be flowering in the *Bar*', 'the tall grasses are also in bloom', and 'the beetle is rattling away in the lonely jungle'. Guru Nanak belonged to the whole world, but he also belonged to the Punjab, particularly to that part of it which is called the *Bar*.

## Pg 18 – 19

### 2 GURU ANGAD (1504-1552)

The chief contribution made by him to the development of the Sikh movement was that he gave definiteness and distinction to the general ideals laid down by Guru Nanak. He took the sayings of his Master, and got them recorded in a special script called *Gurmukhi*.<sup>2</sup>

Thus a nucleus of the Sikh Scripture began to be formed, giving a definite direction to the faith of the disciples. It reminded those who employed it of their duty towards their Guru, and constantly kept alive in their minds the consciousness that they were something distinct from the common mass of Hindus'. It also dealt a powerful blow to the domination of the priestly class, whose importance rested on their knowledge of Sanskrit which had so far been the language of religion. The effect felt in a generation or two was, as Mohsin Fani in his *Dabistan* (p. 233) tells us, that 'the disciples of Nanak...do not read the mantras of Hindus. They do not venerate their temples of idols, nor do they esteem their Avatars. They have no regard for the Sanskrit language, which according to the Hindus is the speech of gods.

Guru Angad, like his predecessor, subjected his sons and Sikhs to severe tests before choosing his successor, and found in Amar Das the fittest person to take his place. He died at the age of 48, on March 29, 1552.

## Pg 22 – 24

### 3 GURU AMAR DAS (1479 – 1574)

The Guru's simple and devotional life attracted large numbers from far and near. Beside Hindus, some very notable Mohammedans joined his faith, and Goindval developed into a big religious centre. A *baoli* (or well) with 84 steps was constructed in 1559 for the use of visitors. It is related that Emperor Akbar, during one of his tours in the Panjab, saw the Guru at Goindval and offered to make a grant for the maintenance of the *Langar* or the common kitchen, but the Guru refused the offer.

The Guru's *Langar* was becoming a great institution. The Guru himself lived on very simple food purchased with his own scanty earnings, but his public kitchen 'was daily supplied with butter refined flour and sugar' (*Var Satta*). Whatever was daily received was daily spent, and nothing was left over for the morrow. Every visitor, whether Hindu or Muslim, was asked to partake of food in the same mess before he could see the Guru. Even Akbar and the Raja of Haripur had to do the same. All had to sit in a line and eat together.<sup>2</sup> No distinction of caste or creed, high or low, was made. Guru Amar Das says, that even if he were a most learned Pandit, 'he would take care to remember that nothing is polluted in the mess. All outlined dining-squares are false. Only God is pure' (*Maru-ki-Var*). In this way, the people were made to renounce their social prejudices and to look upon one another as brothers.

He impressed upon his followers the true value and sanctity of human life. 'All mankind that you see created is the image of God' (*Anand*). 'We may take human body to be the temple, nay, the fort of God' (*Var Ramkali*). When questioned once by his Sikhs as to why he had hastily ridden past a crumbling wall, he had replied that he wanted to teach his disciples that it was their sacred duty to preserve the body up to the last. It was a precious trust of God, to be kept pure and strong by temperance. "Try your best," he said, 'not to drink wine at all' (*Bihagra*). His prohibition of Satee may be understood to have been ordered from the same humane point of view (*Var Suhi*). He was also against the observance of Purda by women.

The number of Sikhs having increased considerably, it was felt necessary by the Guru to organize the scattered Sangats or congregations into a system. Taking his cue evidently from the division of Akbar's empire, he partitioned his whole spiritual domain into 22 provinces, called *Manjis*, each *Manji* being under the charge of a devoted Sikh whose business it was to preach the mission of the Guru and to keep the local body in touch with the centre.

Guru Amar Das declared the Guru's Word to be superior to all the scriptures of the world, and the Sikhs were enjoined to use only the Guru's Word in worship (*Anand*, xxiv). He rejected the six systems of Hindu philosophy in favour of the Guru's dispensation: 'This

system of God is obtained by fortunate ones through the Guru's Word by means of true detachment. The six systems of the Hindus are in vogue nowadays, but the Guru's system is profound and unequalled. It provides the way of salvation, and makes the True One reside in the heart. This system, if adopted with love, can save the whole world' (*Asa*, xi).

As a result of this integration of Sikh doctrine, the Sikhs were becoming more and more self-contained in social matters. Some reform in the matter of marriage and death ceremonies was taken in hand in the time of this Guru.' He introduced the system of performing all ceremonies with the help of the Guru Bani. When dying he ordered his sons, relations and followers to sing only the praises of God on his death, and not to follow the old practice of calling in a Pandit to recite a Puran, to offer barley rolls, to light lamps, etc.)

He breathed his last on September 1, 1574, after consecrating his son-in-law, Ram Das, as his successor.

## **Pg 24 - 25**

### **4 GURU RAM DAS (1534 - 1581)**

Ram Das originally called Jetha, was born of a Sodhi family, in the Chune Mandi, Lahore, on September 24, 1534. While serving, along with other Sikhs in the construction of his Baoli at Goindval, he attracted the attention of Guru Amar Das, and received the hand of his daughter, Bibi Bhani, in marriage. There after he stayed with his father-in-law, and was closely associated with his ministry. He put on record<sup>4</sup> many an incident connected with the struggles that his Master had with his opponents, and as such his writings are a mine of information about the period. He had made himself so indispensable that his choice for the *gaddi* was a forgone conclusion.

On his appointment, in order to avoid any possible unpleasantness with the relatives of the last Guru, he shifted his residence to the present site of Amritsar. Here, to quote the *Amritsar Gazetteer*, 'in 1577 he obtained a grant of the site, together with 500 bighas of land, from the Emperor Akbar, on payment of Rs. 700 Akbari to the zamindars of Tung who owned the land.' The Guru dug the Tank and laid the foundation of the city of Amritsar, then called *Cook Guru*, *Chak Ramdas*, or *Ramdasपुरा*. He invited men of 52 trades to take up their residence there and to open their business in the Guru's market, which is still known as *Guru-ka-bazar*. The city, in the course of time, grew to be biggest trade in the north.

In the search after purely religious matters, we often forget how much the Panjab owes to the Sikh Gurus for advancing the trade and manufacture of the country. If the Mughal emperors were great builders, the Sikh Gurus were no less. Judging from the scanty resources at the disposal of the Gurus, it is nothing short of a marvel for them to have founded so many cities, reservoirs and wells. The immediate effect of the teaching, that religion could be best practised within the secular concerns of life, was that all prejudices against labour and trade were removed, and the people – even the spiritually-minded people – began to take active part in what were called worldly affairs. Gango, a Khatri of the Bassi tribe, came to Guru

Amar Das and asked, 'Lord what shall I do to save myself?' 'Open a bank at Delhi,' said the Guru.<sup>1</sup> Possession of wealth was no longer to be considered as Maya, but as a very salutary and helpful thing in the conduct of human affairs. 'For a religious man, it is not unholy to get wealth, provided he spends it in God's way, and gives and lives in comfort' (*Var Sarong*). Guru Ram Das once said to his Sikhs, 'When a Sikh has an important business in hand, join him and pray for him. If you see that it cannot be carried on without funds, collect subscriptions for him from every quarter, and at the same time contribute something yourselves.' Henceforth we often hear of horse-dealing, banking, embroidery and carpentry among the Sikhs.

Guru Ram Das seeing his end approaching went to Goindval, where he died on September], 1581], leaving three sons, the youngest of whom, Arjun, became the Guru.

### **Pg. 29-31, 33-34, 35**

#### **5 GURU ARJUN (1563 - 1606)**

In 1589 Guru Arjun laid the foundation of the central temple, now called the Golden Temple, in the midst of the tank of Amritsar. Its doors were open on all sides, signifying that the Sikh worship was open to all. The Guru set out on a tour in the districts to propagate his religion and to organise his Sangats. He emphasised the superiority of congregational worship and the merit of saving something for the common fund.

Sikhism was essentially a religion of the Name. In it the most obvious religious exercise was the recitation or singing of the Guru's Word, to the exclusion of all other ceremony or ritual. Seeing the ; importance of this practice many clever persons, like Prithia, had begun to mix up spurious writings with the true compositions of the Gurus and to make them current among the Sikhs. There was a danger of confusion in the creed and the ritual; and the Guru who was responsible for the organisation of Sikhism on a sound basis had to ensure unity of belief and practice. He undertook therefore to collect the genuine writings of his predecessors and, adding to them his own, to prepare a grand volume out of them. As we have seen, some of the work had already been done by the Second and the Third Gurus, and the manuscripts lay with Saba Mohan at Goindval. · Guru Arjun went there personally, and brought them reverently to Amritsar. As these Goindval manuscripts do not contain all the writings included in the Holy Granth, he must have consulted other sources too to get at the complete works required. He sat down at Ramsar, a beautiful solitary spot to the south of Amritsar, and began his work of composition and compilation.

His own contribution was the biggest, and included some of the sublimest pieces, like the *Sukhmani*, which being free from any touch of sectarianism have been favourite readings with non-Sikhs in Sindh as well as in the Panjab. His chief qualities as a writer are intellectual vigour, classical restraint, and serenity of emotion arising from practical needs of life. There is in his writings a still sad music of humanity, a lyrical cry coming from the heart that has known suffering and has found peace. It is a peace behind which lies a tremendous struggle with pain, culminating in victory, 'like the calm of the weather brought about by a shower of rain following on a storm of dust and wind.' (*Kabir*).

Besides his own and his predecessors' compositions, he also included selections from the writings of fifteen Hindu and Muslim saints, Kabir, Farid, Namdev, Ravidas, Bhikhan, etc., most of whom belonged to the so-called depressed or untouchable classes. Five at least (Farid, Bhikhan, Satta, Balvand and Mardana) were Mohammedans. The selection was based, not on doctrinal but the lyrical and living value of the pieces.

The idea of making this selection was not new. It was inherent in the cosmopolitan nature of Sikhism, and had begun with its founder. That Guru Nanak himself had the writings of Kabir with him is proved by the fact that many of Kabir's expressions are embedded in his own; e. g.

Akbar died in 1605, and his place was taken by his son, Jahangir. This man was not so liberal in his views as his father, and when ascending the throne had promised his adherents that he would defend the Mohammedan religion.<sup>6</sup> He did not interfere with holy men as such, but true to his promise he would not allow any strong religious centres to be formed within his dominions, because they might develop into disturbers of peace. He did not tolerate conversions of Muslims to other religions.

It appears from his own *Tuzuk* that he had already formed a prejudice against the Sikh movement. He says about Guru Arjun :

So many of the simple-minded Hindus, nay. many foolish Muslims too, had been fascinated by his ways and teachings. He was noised about as a religious and worldly leader. They called him *Guru*, and from all directions crowds of fools would come to him and express great devotion to him. This busy traffic had been carried on for three or four generations. *For years the thought had been presenting itself to my mind that either I should put an end to this false traffic, or he should be brought into the fold of Islam* (p. 35).

Jahangir got the long-sought chance in the rebellion of Khusrau, and he did not want to miss it. He was told that during his flight Prince Khusrau had been visited by Guru Arjun, who had talked of past affairs with him and had made a saffron-mark on his forehead. This was interpreted as a gesture of blessing in favour of the rebel, and the Guru was ordered to be arrested. No enquiry was made, and no trial held. Jahangir simply says, 'I fully knew his heresies, and I ordered that he should be brought into my presence, that his houses and children be made over to Murtaza Khan, that his property be confiscated, and that he should be put to death with tortures.'

The real fact is that the Guru was not interested in any claimant to the throne; and Khusrau, if he ever met the Guru, must have gone to him casually, as all men in trouble do, 'hoping apparently that this would bring him good fortune.'<sup>2</sup>

The Guru was handed over to Chandu Shah, who, according to Sikh accounts, had a private grudge against him. He was subjected to all sorts of tortures in the burning heat of Lahore; and finally, to add to his agonies, his blistered body was thrown into the cold water of the Ravi, which carried it away to its final rest. This occurred on May 30, 1606.



**Pg. 35 – 39, 40, 44, 46**

**6 GURU HARGOBIND (1595 - 1644)**

Historians usually see at this stage in Sikh history a sudden change in the character of Guruship. The Guru who had been a fakir now assumed the position of a *sacch apadshah* (or true king), his church a sort of theocracy, his *masands* viceroys and their excellencies, his collection of tithes a system of compulsory taxation flowing into a central treasury. The whole movement, in fact, is represented as having been transformed from something peaceful and spiritual into a mere military camp.

We have seen how the allegation of the assumption of regal power by Guru Arjun is based upon a wrong translation of a passage in the *Dabistan-i-Mazahib*. It will appear from the writings of the early Gurus, and especially those of the bards who began to write in the time of the Second Guru, that the terms *saccha padshah*, *raj*, *takht*, *darbar* etc., were not later innovations, but had been used from the beginning. They are eastern euphemisms used in respect of all revered fakirs. It is also unscientific to suppose that there could be any sudden departure in the old line of work established by the earlier Gurus. The development must have been gradual. It happened that the Mughal emperors in the beginning were not intolerant. It also happened that Sikhism began with the establishment of the Mughal rule. Both being in their infancy, the emperors, on the one hand, had not that command over the empire which they got with Akbar and his successors; and on the other hand, Sikhism in the eyes of the public had not yet assumed any great proportions. Many causes like these conspired to make the progress of Sikhism a little smoother in the beginning. After Akbar's laxity of principles, however, it was thought better in the interest of Islam to change the state policy towards non Muslims. And, therefore, we hear more of persecutions after him. A new religion, which has active followers, is always felt to be a source of anxiety to the ruling community. For great religions do not bring with them only new doctrines; they also give a newer and stronger life to the nation, which it feels in every part of its being. It is stirred up socially, economically and politically as well as spiritually.

When Guru Nanak began his work, we have seen how he felt the political degradation of his people as much their religious deterioration. He wanted to see them free in every way, from the foreign yoke as well as from the trammels of the priestly class. According to him, 'Only fools or idiots try to rule over others' (*Basant*). He condemned the Lodhis for their cowardice, and upbraided the Mughal invaders for their tyranny. He lashed up the ebbing patriotism of his people, who abjectly offered loyalty to the alien rulers, and would mimic their fashions and manners in order to be acceptable to them (*Var Asa*; xvi). In his *Japji*, where he lays down the stages of man's development, he places heroes, mighty and brave, in the highest region, only next to that where God Himself dwells (xxxvii). He deplored the use of a foreign language in place of the people's own mother-tongue (*Basant*). All this was not spiritual, but very very secular. And yet it issued from the heart of a *Bhakta*, who saw that earthly freedom was rooted in spiritual freedom, and could not be separated from it. This may sound queer to those who are accustomed to think of saints as mere recluses, mumbling *mantras*, with hands folded and eyes upturned. The Sikh Gurus, however, were of a different mould. They were practical leaders as well as meditating saints, and thought it not inconsistent with their religious ideals to take active measures to teach service of mankind as much through

advancement of trade, art and learning, as through holy communion, high-thinking and noble living.

They were very gentle and humble, yet on occasions, when their dignity or self-respect was touched, they knew how to be firm, as Guru Angad did when he was threatened by Humayun. By the time of the Third and Fourth Gurus the Sikh community had become large enough to attract the attention and also the hostility of those whose interests were affected by its rise. Guru Ram Das, in his *Va rGauri*, xiv, describes the Sikh movement of his time as an arena of opposing forces, wherein the Guru had to fight heroically against the odds. In the train of success came greatness, even worldly greatness, and the Guru broadened his shoulders to receive it. 'Why should we be afraid of its coming?' he says. 'It is God's own glory that increases thus. Mark, O brethren, this arena (i. e., the Sikh church) of the true and beloved God, who with His own force has brought low all those people.' Guru Arjun too had come to talk of his struggles in terms of wrestling matches (*Sri Rag*). Under his stimulating leadership the Sikhs had acquired an intensity of character which steeled them against all tyranny and corruption. After describing the work of organization he had effected among his Sikhs, he says, 'Now the order of the Merciful had gone forth that no one shall molest another.' And the Sikhs had been sufficiently prepared to understand what that order meant for them. Bir Bal, a minister of Akbar, imposed a capitation tax on the Khatri of Amritsar, who led by Guru Arjun refused to pay it. Bir Bal threatened to bring an army to punish the Guru, but he was called away to the Frontier where he was killed, and nothing came of it.<sup>1</sup> Thus was war averted, but it is clear from this incident that the clash which came in the time of Guru Hargobind was due much earlier. Only an accident postponed it. The death of Guru Arjun, however, convinced the Sikhs that they must arm themselves and fight, if they wanted to live.

Guru Hargobind was only eleven years old when he came to the *gaddi* of his martyred father. He had been carefully trained for the high office, which, under the changed circumstances, was not only a place of honour but of great danger as well, and no ordinary man was expected to acquit himself well in it. Seeing the needs of the time, his father had placed him with Bhai Buddha, the veteran Sikh, who was asked to make a soldier-saint out of him. He instructed him in the sacred lore, and taught him the use of offensive and defensive weapons, besides riding, hunting, wrestling and many other manly sports. So he grew up to be an all-round man, healthy and strong, as well as saintly and enlightened.<sup>2</sup>

On the occasion of his accession, he wore two swords, one to represent spiritual and the other temporal interests. He sent a circular letter to his *Masands* to ask the Sikhs to bring, in future, arms and horses as a part of their offerings. He strengthened the city of Amritsar by putting up a small fortification, called *Lohgarh*. In 1609, he also built a meeting place for Sikhs and called it the *Akal Takht*, or the Throne of the Almighty. Here, besides praying and preaching, talks were held on questions affecting the welfare of the community. He enrolled a bodyguard of 52 stout Sikhs, who formed the nucleus of his future army. Five hundred youths came from Majha, Malva and the Doab to offer their services to dare and die for their religion. They did not want any pay. The Guru gave them each a horse and simple weapons of war, and formed a little army out of them. He kept up their spirits by taking them out on hunting expeditions, by arranging games and wrestling matches, and by holding symposiums of martial music. The morning service was held, as usual, in the Golden Temple, where besides other hymns certain divine odes, called *Vars*, which had been set to heroic tunes by

Guru Arjun, were sung. The Guru also gave sermons and led the congregations in prayer. In the afternoon physical feats were performed in the courtyard before the Akal Takht, or visitors were received and complaints heard and redressed. The Sikhs were thus encouraged to have their disputes decided among themselves. Under Guru Hargobind was also established the custom, which still continues. Of choirs moving nightly round the Golden Temple and, with the blare of trumpets and flare of torches, singing hymns in stirring tunes. All these programmes put a new life into the drooping hearts of Sikhs who, as the Sikh chronicle records, began to revive like vegetables in the rainy season.

Jahangir lived for several years after this, but he never gave any further trouble to Guru Hargobind. Rather he tried to befriend him. He seemed to have been convinced that he had been misled in - handling the case of Guru Arjun, and throwing the blame on Chandu Shah handed him over to Guru Hargobind. Chandu Shah was paraded 'in the streets of Lahore, where a grain-parcher struck him with a ladle and killed him on the spot. Jahangir would go hunting with the Guru, and would make much of his company. He even paid a visit to Amritsar, and offered to complete the building of the Akal Takht at his own expense. The Guru, however, declined the offer, saying, "Let me and my Sikhs raise this Throne of God with the labour of our own bodies and with the contributions from our own little resources. I wish to make it a symbol of my Sikhs' service and sacrifice, and not a monument to a king's generosity."

Guru Hargobind had won four battles, but as his purpose had always been only defensive, he did not acquire even an inch of territory as a result of these victories. There was something far greater involved in this warfare than a mere dispute over a hawk or a horse. A new heroism was rising in the land, of which the object, then dimly seen, was to create the will to resist the mighty power of the foreign aggressors, called the 'Toorks' (who were ordinarily called 'Mussalmans' when they behaved in good neighbourly manner).

He was in favour of practising common virtues in everyday life, inspired by a sense of divine presence everywhere. He lived like a simple fakir, and gave up even the use of pillows. His Sikhs too were able to revert to their peaceful occupations. Some of them who were more adventurous were sent to distant places as missionaries or traders. Bidhi Chand was sent to preach Sikhism in Bengal, while Bhai Gurdas was sent to Kabul to buy horses. It speaks for an all-round development of the Sikh character that a warrior, at such a short notice, should be sent out as a missionary, and a scholar, as a trader.

As his promising son, Gurditta had died in 1638, the Guru was compelled to prepare somebody else to take his place as the future Guru. He appointed Har Rai to succeed him, and himself died on March 3, 1644. His death was considered a national calamity, and the estimation in which he was held by the Sikhs may be judged from the fact that a great many of them volunteered to bum themselves on his funeral pile.

## 7 GURU HAR RAI (1630 – 1661)

He was born at Kiratpur on January 30, 1630. <sup>1</sup> From the beginning he had shown a good combination of strength and tenderness. He was a mighty hunter. and yet he was too kind-hearted to kill the animals he had chased or captured He would bring them home, and feed

and protect them in a zoo. One day during his childhood, as he was passing through a garden, his loose coat broke the stems of some flowers which fell to the ground. The sight was too much for him and brought tears to his eyes. He was very fond of singing Farid's lines: 'All men's hearts are jewels; it is wicked to distress them. If you desire to see the Beloved, grieve no man's heart.' He said, 'The temple or the mosque may be repaired or rebuilt, but not the broken heart.' He always asked his visitors whether they kept free kitchens and shared their food with others. Nothing pleased him better than to do good to others. It was from him that the ancestors of the rulers of Patiala, Nabha and Jind received the blessing of royalty. A similar blessing was bestowed on Buddha Singh, an ancestor of Maharaja Ranjit Singh.<sup>3</sup>

Yet we should not forget that Guru Har Rai was a soldier. He kept a strong force of 2200 horsemen ready to be employed whenever necessary. The Guru, however, was bent on following the policy of peace. When the sons of Shah Jahan were fighting for the throne of Delhi, the Guru was once obliged to take out his forces, but he took good care not to shed blood. Dara Shikoh, like many other sufis, was an admirer of Sikhism, and seems to have had some personal regard for the Guru, who had once saved his life by sending him a rare medicine. Pursued by the army of Aurangzeb, Prince Dara went to Goindval, and asked the Guru to prevent his being captured. The Guru sent his men to hold the passage of the river Beas against the pursuing party, until the refugee prince was able to escape.

## 9 GURU TEGH BAHADUR

He set out with his family on a long tour designed to foster the Sikh faith where already established and to preach its doctrine throughout lower India: He passed throughout Malwa and Bangar, teaching the people to give up violence and thieving, and to live in peace with their neighbours. He caused many tanks and wells to be dug for public use. They must have been a real boon to the people of that parched region. His progress through the country created such a stir that the Mughal authorities seem to have grown suspicious of his activities, and he was hauled up before the Emperor.' Raja Ram Singh, son of Mirza Raja Jai Singh, explained to the Emperor that there was nothing dangerous about the Guru, who was a mere fakir. He stood surety for him, and the trouble came to an end.

There flourished quite a network of prosperous Sikh Sangats and monasteries all over. From Rajmahal in the west to Sylhet in the east, and from Dhubri in the north to Banskhal and Fatehkachehri in the south, there was hardly a place of importance, during the days of Mughal viceroyalty, where some Sikh temple did not exist or some Sikh ascetic had not established himself and gathered a number of followers round him. The movement had spread even to some islands like Sondip, as early as Shah Jahan's time.' These Sangats were not only places of worship, but as usual served the useful purpose of wayside inns where food and shelter was given free to the poor and indigent weary wayfarers. These Sangats had been well organised by Almast and Nathe Sahib. Dacca was the *Hazuri Sangat* or the head Sangat of these parts, with a number of others under it, and in turn was controlled by the Guru from Anandpur.<sup>2</sup> Beside local Sangats, there were always present a large number of Sikh merchants from the Panjab and Sind. As is evident from the letters addressed to them by Guru Tegh Bahadur, they were ever anxious to keep themselves connected with their spiritual guide, and occasionally sent offerings to him. Guru Tegh Bahadur was glad to have an opportunity of moving among them and making personal contacts with them.

On his return he found the people terrorised by the new policy of religious persecution launched by Aurangzeb. The general order,~ issued by the Emperor to his governors in 1669,

that all the temples and schools of the Hindus should be demolished, was having its effect. The Sikhs too, as Khafi Khan tells us, came in for their share. Their leaders were being exterminated, and their temples destroyed.<sup>3</sup> The Guru spent some time in thinking of his future plans. He wanted to do something which would shake the rules into-reason and rouse the people out of their lethargy.

In the meantime he sent for his family from Patna. His son, Gobind Das, had grown a stripling boy of great promise. 'He gave him instruction of different kinds,' and made him fit in every way to take his place. One day, seeing his father lost in thought, young Gobind asked him the reason. The Guru said, 'India is in the terrible grip of the foreigner. It can be saved only if a great soul were to sacrifice himself. But where to find such a person?' The child, who was only nine years old, replied, 'For this purpose, dear father, who is more worthy than you?' Hearing this the Guru was satisfied that he had found a worthy successor in his son.

He started on a tour in 1673, exhorting people to give up all fear and to face tyranny with resolute calmness. His motto was : 'Frighten not, and fear not' (*Sloka* 16).

During these travels, which lasted for about two years, the Guru moved with a large following, which changed from place to place according to the number of Sikhs living in the vicinity, and received the homage of the people along with many offerings. These proceedings, though usual with every Guru, were misrepresented by the local news writers as 'forcible exactions', and it was feared that the Guru might gather strength enough to prove a danger to the state. The Emperor ordered the arrest of the Guru who was found at Agra and brought to Delhi. He was thrown into prison, and closely guarded. He was called upon to embrace Islam, which he refused to do. One of his companions, Bhai Mati Das was sawn alive; three others escaped. He himself was put in chains. In this condition he wrote a letter to his son at Anandpur, saying:

My strength is exhausted; I am in chains; and have no resource left.  
 God alone is my refuge now; He will succour me; as He did the  
 elephant [in the classical story].  
 My associates and companions have all abandoned me; no one  
 has remained with me to the last.  
 In this calamity God alone is my support"

To this he received the following reply from his son:

Strength is there; your fetters are loosed; every resource is at hand.  
 Nanak, everything is within your power, it is only you who can  
 assist yourself.

This reply very much heartened the Guru about the future of his country, and nominating Gobind Das as his successor, he made himself ready to face death. He declared his belief that

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When Guru Gobind is there, the Lord's Name and His saints will flourish.

He refused to perform any miracles to appease his persecutors. In the beginning of November, 1675, another order arrived from the Emperor, and the Guru was publicly beheaded on the 11th in the Chandani Chauk<sup>4</sup> of Delhi. Guru Gobind Singh recorded the event of his father's death in his *Vichitra Natak* in the following words:

Thus did the Master protect the frontal mark and the sacrificial thread of the Hindus;

Thus did he bring about a great event in this dark age.  
 He did so much for God's people,  
 Giving up his life without uttering a groan.  
 He suffered martyrdom for the sake of religion,  
 Laying down his head without surrendering his principles.  
 God's people feel shame.  
 In performing miracles which are mere tricks of mountebanks and cheats.  
 Breaking his potsherd on the head of the Delhi king, he departed to the city of God.  
 Nobody ever did such a thing as he.  
 At his departure a wail went forth from the denizens of the earth.  
 And hail! all-hail! was heard from heaven.

## 10 GURU GOBIND (1666 – 1708)

Guru Gobind, called Guru Gobind Singh after the institution of Sikh baptism, was only nine years old, when his father was martyred in Delhi. The effect of the blow was very staggering at first. No body from the high-class Sikhs came forward to claim the dismembered body of Guru Tegh Bahadur for the purpose of cremation. Only a Lubana Sikh, with a few tribesmen, eluding the vigilance of guards, took the headless trunk in a cart to his hut <sup>1</sup> outside the city, and burnt it with all his belongings, in order to make out that it was an accident. One Jaita, a Ranghreta Sikh, belonging to the sweeper class, took up the head of the Guru and hurried away with it to Anandpur, where he presented it to the Guru's son. Guru Gobind Singh, who was a mere child, was touched with the extreme devotion of the Ranghreta, and flinging his arms round his neck declared, 'Here I embrace, through you, all the Ranghretas as the Guru's own sons.' He was very sorry to learn, however, that at the time of trial very few Sikhs, with the exception of the immediate followers, had shown the courage of their convictions. When questioned by the officials as to whether they were Sikhs, they had the weakness to deny their religion. The Guru saw in this the danger of a backsliding among the Sikhs. He vowed therefore that he would make it impossible for the Sikhs to hide their creed in future, even if they were among thousands, by giving them some distinguishing marks.<sup>4</sup>

He placed literary activity in the forefront of his programme of national reconstruction. He translated the old stories of Indian heroes, as found in the Puranas, the Ramayana and the Mahabharata, and engaged fifty-two poets to help him in this heavy task.<sup>2</sup>

His Purpose <sup>1</sup> in creating this literature was to infuse a new spirit among his followers and to steel their hearts against all injustice and tyranny. The tyranny that then prevailed in the country was not only political but religious as well. If some of the rulers subjected the people to certain disabilities and hardships, the Brahmins and Mullas, where they were concerned, were no less cruel in keeping millions of their countrymen in a sort of religious bondage. If the political rulers were treating the subject people like so many vermin, their religious leaders were doing no less in looking down upon so many of their fellowmen as untouchables. The political tyranny was discriminate and occasional, but the religious tyranny was indiscriminate and continuous, being practised everyday in kitchens, at village

wells, in temples and hundreds of other places of mutual resort. It was more heinous than any other crime. Guru Gobind Singh says:

*The sins committed in the name of religion are such as to put even greatest sins to the blush.*

The success of Guru Gobind Singh – for all was attributed to him – caused some anxiety to the Emperor, who had already sent a warning<sup>2</sup> to the Guru not to assemble his Sikhs. Now he sent his son, Prince Muazzim, afterwards known as Bahadur Shah, to manage the affairs of the Panjab which were in disorder. The Prince himself took his position at Lahore, and sent Mirza Beg with a force to chastise the Guru and the Rajas. The Rajas were severely punished, but the Guru was left alone through the intercession of a Sikh, Bhai Nand Lal, who was a secretary to the Prince and had influence with both the parties. He seems to have brought about some kind of understanding between the Government and the Guru who made the following significant statement recorded in the *Vichitra Natak* (xiii. 9)

*The House of Baba [Nanak] and of Babar Both derive their authority from God Himself, Recognise the former as supreme in religion, And the latter supreme in secular affairs.*

The Guru was given some respite to think and to mature his future plans. He had worked among the people of the semi-independent states of the Shivaliks, and had tried to rouse them to a sense of national unity, but he soon discovered that, being steeped in superstition and old ideas of religion, they could not rise above their caste and racial prejudices to combine for any national purpose.

Sometimes they would make a common cause with the enemy and combine even against him, their deliverer, as Bhim Chand and others had done in the Hussaini War. Political reform must be preceded by a general renaissance and religious awakening. He therefore resolved to break the old shackles with greater precision than had been done before and to reorganise society on the basis of common belief and common aspirations. In doing so he did not depart in any way from the principles taught by his predecessors. Rather he built on the foundations laid by them. 'Gobind himself, in fact, as well as his work, was the natural product of the process of evolution that had been going on ever since the foundation of Sikhism. The harvest which ripened in the time of Guru Gobind Singh had been sown by Nanak and watered by his successors.. The sword which craved the Khalsa's way to glory was, undoubtedly, forged by Gobind, but the steel had been provided by Nanak.' He considered the mission of all his predecessors to be one and the same, and his own as its consummation. 'The generality of men,' he says, 'take them as different from one another; very few recognise them as one in spirit. But only those realise perfection who do recognise them as one.'<sup>12</sup> The apparent differences which some writers<sup>1</sup> see in their objectives were due only to the local and occasional circumstances, and did not show any departure from the original design. The Gurus, as for example, did intend to abolish the caste system. We cannot imagine Guru Nanak saying with his tongue in his cheek that 'caste is nonsense' (*Sri Rag*) and that 'nobody should be asked his caste' (*Asa*). Still it did not die out completely. The reason is not far to seek. It takes two parties to effect a reform: the reformer and the party to be reformed. The Guru knew what sort of material they had to handle. The corruption which had

taken centuries to gather could not be eradicated at once. The difficulty of the task may be gauged from the fact that Islam and Christianity too, with much bigger resources, have tried to break this steel frame, but who can say that they have succeeded? The Sikh Gurus did make a headway in the beginning, when hosts of Mohammedans and low-caste people were assimilated in the fold of Sikhism. But when the forces released by Sikhism brought on religious persecution by the Mughals, the Sikhs and Hindus found themselves in the same boat; and, as would happen in such cases, they had to club their resources together, and to suspend all their intercommunal controversies. The caste system could not be broken in these circumstances, although its pride which was a hindrance in the way of true religion was totally removed. The Jats who were considered Sudras enjoyed the greatest prestige along with the Khatri, and the Brahmins were no longer held in esteem. 'All the four varnas were equalised.' (Bhai Gurdas).

It was reserved for Guru Gobind Singh to cut at the root of all such institutions as hindered the unification and consolidation of the nation, and to rear a self-contained and compact body of men who would be pure enough to free themselves from the oppression of priests and rulers, and would at the same time be strong enough to maintain this freedom.

On the Baisakhi day, March 30 of 1699, he called a big meeting at Anandpur. When all were seated, he drew out his sword and cried, 'Is there anyone here who would lay down his life for dharma? At this the whole assembly was thrown into consternation; but the Guru went on repeating his demand. At the third call, Daya Ram, a Khatri of Lahore, rose from his seat and offered himself. The Guru took him into an adjoining enclosure, where a few goats were kept tied, and seating him there cut off a goat's head. He came out with the dripping weapon and flourishing it before the multitude asked again, 'Is there any other Sikh here who will offer himself as a sacrifice?' At this Dharam Das, a Jat of Delhi, came forward and was taken into the enclosure, where another goat was killed. In the same way three other men stood up one after another and offered themselves for the sacrifice. One was Muhkam Chand, a washerman of Dwarka; another was Himmat, a cook of Jagannath; and the third was Sahib Chand, a barber of Bedar. The Guru after dressing the five in handsome clothes brought them before the assembly. He baptised them with sweetened water stirred with a dagger and called them his Beloved Ones. Then he spoke at length on his mission, and, according to Bute Shah and Ahmed Shah Batalia, is reported to have said, among other things :

I wish you all to embrace one creed and follow one path, obliterating all difference of religion. Let the four Hindu castes, who have different rules laid down for them in the Shastras, abandon them altogether and, adopting the way of cooperation, mix freely with one another. Let no one deem himself superior to another. Do not follow the old scriptures. Let none pay heed to the Ganges and other places of pilgrimage which are considered holy in the Hindu religion, or adore the Hindu deities, such as Rama, Krishna, Brahma and Durga, but all should believe in Guru Nanak and his successors. Let men of the four castes receive my baptism, eat out of the same vessel, and feel no disgust or contempt for one another.

When the Guru had administered baptism<sup>2</sup> to his five tried Sikhs he stood up before them with folded hands, and begged them to baptise him in the same way as he had baptised them. ~ They were astonished at such a strange request, but he silenced them by saying that he too wanted to be one of them, that as he was their Guru, they collectively should be his Guru. After this there remain no difference between him and his baptised Sikhs. They were to be his Khalsa,<sup>4</sup> his embodiment, nay, his other self, his beloved Ideal (*isht suhird*), and



therefore, quite competent to take his place after him. Thenceforth the ceremony of conversion to Sikhism was to be conducted by a commission of five Beloved Ones.

The greatest lever used by the Guru in uplifting his people was self-respect and human dignity. The Sikhs used to be domineered by the Masands. Guru Gobind Singh freed his followers from the demeaning influence of these men, who had gradually degenerated into mere parasites, by abolishing their order and declaring them ostracised. The ceremony of initiation, as we have seen, was modified to suit the changed circumstances. The water used in baptism, instead of being touched with the Guru's toe, was now to be stirred with a double-edged dagger. The mode of salutation was also changed. Instead of touching one another's feet, as was the custom before, the Sikhs were to fold their hands in front and hail each other as 'the Purified Ones of the wonderful Lord who is always victorious.' The Guru began to celebrate the Holi festival in his own way. He called it Hola Mahalla. On the day following the Hindu festival he held a military parade of all his Sikhs, who ca. 'le alit in their best and went through a sort of mimic battle. The Khalsa was inspired by a sense of divine mission to right the wrongs of the world; and, in the discharge of his duties, no fear of earthly power was to stand in his way. Such was his confidence in the strength of his righteous cause that each Sikh called himself a unit of one lakh and a quarter. Even now one might occasionally meet a Sikh who would announce his arrival as the advent of a host of a hundred and twenty-five thousand.

The Guru himself recognised the worth and dignity of his nation, and would always refer to the assembly of Sikhs with great respect and admiration. It was in these terms he once spoke of his followers: 'It is through *them* that I have gained my experience; with *their* help have I subdued my enemies. Through *their* favour am I exalted; otherwise there are millions of ordinary men like me whose lives are of no account,' 'Let him who wishes to see me go to an assembly of Sikhs and approach them with faith and reverence; he will surely see me among Ithem.' Although a leader, he nevertheless considered himself a servant of his people: 'To serve them,' he said, 'pleases my heart; no other service is so dear to my soul. All the substance in my house, nay, my, soul and body are at their disposal.'

Guru Gobind Singh, through his baptism, poured his life into his Sikhs, and invested them with his own personality. There was about him a stem olympian air, which he imparted to his followers. His impress not only elevated and altered the constitution of their minds, but-contrary to the experience of ethnological experts-it also operated materially and gave amplitude to their physical frames.) They came to be regarded as models of physical beauty and stateliness of manner. A tremendous change was effected in the whole tone of national character. Even those people who had been considered as dregs of humanity were changed, as if by magic, into something rich and strange. The sweepers, barbers and confectioners, who had never so much as touched the sword and whose whole generations had lived as groveling slaves of the so-called higher classes, became, under the stimulating leadership of Guru Gobind Singh, doughty warriors who never shrank from fear and who were ready to rush into the jaws of death at the bidding of their Guru.

The aim of Guru Gobind Singh in founding the Khalsa was to build up a nation of the Purified Ones who would be free from the evils of religion and society. But the rulers of the time thought, he was organising a force to attack and destroy them. Anandpur was in the land of Kahlur, surrounded by other hill states. The Hindu rajas of those states saw in the activities of the Guru a threat to their own religion and power, and the Raja of Kahlur

sent him a letter asking him to quit his state or to pay him a tribute as a sign of submission. The Guru refused to do so, and war began.

On the way, when at Dina, the Guru had sent a letter in Persian verse in reply to a summons from Aurangzeb. He called it *Zafarnama*, or an Epistle of Victory. In this he reminded him of his ill-treatment, and told him that, though so many of his Sikhs, besides his sons, had been killed, he was still unconquered. 'For what is the use of putting out a few sparks, when you raise a mighty flame instead?' It meant that the work which the Guru had started had become a worldwide movement, and therefore it could not be crushed by defeating or killing a few individuals.

The Gurus had led the Sikhs from generation to generation in the practice of qualities which make a great nation; and now that the task was over, the last of them merged his personality in the ranks of his disciples. All Sikh history had been moving towards this divine event. There was to be no personal Guru in future. The whole Sikh community, in its organised form called the *Panth*, was to guide itself by the teachings of the Gurus as incorporated in the Holy Granth, and also by the collective sense of the community